

Homework #1

Functional Brief

Instructions

Prompt

You have joined a simulated enterprise as a junior AI analyst. Before you can put AI to work, you need to understand the function you sit in and where AI can realistically add value. Draw on the Week 1–2 readings, Ethan Mollick’s [“Using AI Right Now”](#) and the [MIT Sloan piece on scaling AI](#), to frame your thinking.

1. **Choose your context.** Select one simulated company, GreenThreads (sustainable apparel) or QuickBite (fast-casual food), and one business function: Marketing, HR, Operations, or Finance. You will keep this company and function for the entire quarter.
2. **Describe the function.** In 2–3 paragraphs, explain what your function is responsible for inside your chosen company, who it serves, and how its success is measured.
3. **Map the workflows.** Document the function’s typical daily, weekly, and quarterly tasks. A simple table or labeled list is fine. The goal is to make the real work visible.
4. **Identify and classify AI opportunities.** Pick 5–7 specific tasks where AI tools could add value. Tag each one by the level of effort it represents, using the MIT Sloan framework: **Level 1** (boost individual productivity), **Level 2** (build AI into a well-defined task or role), or **Level 3** (automate a production or operational process). Then rank your opportunities by impact and feasibility. For your top one or two, *estimate* the value in concrete terms (e.g., hours saved per week, error reduction, added throughput) and state in one sentence how the opportunity aligns with what your function is trying to achieve.
5. **Set guardrails and local rules.** Identify **at least 2 places** where applying AI in your function introduces risk. For each, decide whether it belongs to company-wide **executive guardrails** (privacy, security, intellectual property, ethics) or to **the local rules** your own function should write, the “judgment is local” idea from the MIT Sloan reading, and state the specific rule or mitigation you would put in place.
6. **Show your tools and verification.** Use an LLM to research or pressure-test part of your brief. In 2–3 sentences, name the tool and the model tier you used (fast vs. powerful), what you used it for, and how you checked its output for accuracy. As Mollick advises, *use AI on topics you understand well enough to catch its mistakes*.

Length: roughly 2–3 pages. Write for a hiring manager who should finish your brief understanding both your function and your judgment about where AI belongs.

Submission Instructions

- Submit a single Google Doc on Campuswire, including your chosen company (GreenThreads or QuickBite), and function in the document header.
- Cite any external sources or case materials you reference.
- Files turned in late follow the course Late Assignment Policy in the syllabus.

Grading Rubric

100 points total

#	Category & Target Behavior	Excellent	Good	Poor	Missing
1	Function & Company Context (15 pts) <i>Clearly explains the function's role, stakeholders, and success metrics within the chosen company.</i>	Precise, well-grounded description; success metrics are specific and credible.	Solid description; metrics present but somewhat general.	Vague or generic; little tie to the chosen company.	Not addressed.
2	Workflow Map (15 pts) <i>Documents daily, weekly, and quarterly tasks for the function.</i>	Complete, realistic map across all three cadences; easy to follow.	Covers most tasks; one cadence thin.	Sparse or unrealistic; cadences blurred.	No workflow map.
3	AI Opportunity Identification & Classification (30 pts) <i>Names 5–7 opportunities, tags each by MIT Sloan level, ranks by impact/feasibility, and quantifies the top one or two.</i>	5–7 sharp opportunities, correctly leveled and ranked, with credible concrete value and a clear alignment rationale.	Adequate set; leveling, ranking, or value estimate partial.	Few or generic opportunities; no real leveling or ranking.	No opportunities identified.
4	Risk, Guardrails & Local Rules (15 pts) <i>Flags ≥2 AI risks and sorts each into executive guardrails vs. local function rules, with mitigations.</i>	Thoughtful, function-specific risks correctly assigned to guardrails or local rules, with practical mitigations.	Two risks named and mostly sorted; mitigations light.	Risks generic, unsorted, or mitigations absent.	No risks discussed.
5	Tools & Verification (10 pts) <i>Uses an AI tool to support the brief and documents the tool, model tier, use, and accuracy check.</i>	Clear, specific account of tool/model used and a real verification step.	Tool use noted; verification light.	Vague or no real tool use; no verification.	Not addressed.
6	Professionalism & Clarity (15 pts) <i>Reads like employer-ready analyst work; organized, correct, well-cited.</i>	Clean, well-structured, error-free, properly cited.	Mostly clean; minor issues.	Disorganized or error-heavy.	Not submitted in usable form.